

Quick Buying Cheat Sheet

Stand in the shop → estimate U.S. retail → read your max price.

Researched 2026-08-11. Asking-price reference, not an appraisal.

Work-Backward Table

Expected U.S. Retail	Ideal Outright	Max Outright	Preferred Consign. Net	Max Consign. Net
\$250	\$100	\$125	\$125	\$150
\$350	\$140	\$175	\$175	\$210
\$500	\$200	\$250	\$250	\$300
\$750	\$300	\$375	\$375	\$450
\$1,000	\$400	\$500	\$500	\$600
\$1,500	\$600	\$750	\$750	\$900
\$2,000	\$800	\$1,000	\$1,000	\$1,200
\$2,500	\$1,000	\$1,250	\$1,250	\$1,500
\$5,000	\$2,000	\$2,500	\$2,500	\$3,000

Outright = pay 40–50% of retail. Consignment net to jeweler = 50–60% of retail. Add landed costs: ~\$60+ insured shipping, 5.5% duty, 3% processing, 5% returns reserve.

Category Reality Check (observed asking-price spans)

Gem category	Observed asking-price span	Priced comps
Ceylon / Sri Lankan Moonstone	\$60–\$7,480	14/22
Rainbow Moonstone / White Labradorite	\$170–\$1,590	6/12
Ceylon / Sri Lankan Blue Sapphire	\$170–\$128,000	10/21
Star Sapphire	\$280–\$10,660	6/11
Padparadscha Sapphire	\$2,588–\$405,000	7/10
Chrysoberyl Cat's Eye	\$58–\$25,500	10/12
Alexandrite (Colour-Change)	\$2,080–\$167,912	7/11
Spinel	\$1,491–\$52,280	11/15
Zircon (Natural Mineral)	\$595–\$19,810	4/14
Hessonite Garnet	\$245–\$925	3/13

Top Red Flags

- Origin claimed but NO documentation on an expensive stone.
- "Unheated sapphire" with no lab report at a high price.
- Seller won't give you the carat weight or the mm dimensions.
- Metal purity is vague ("gold colour", "German silver", no hallmark).
- Tourist retail price presented as "wholesale" or "special price for you".
- Price justified mainly by a story (mine visit, family, luck) rather than the stone.
- A big premium with no visible stone quality (weak flash / weak star / dull colour) to justify it.
- "Certificate" from an unknown local lab, or a photocopy that doesn't match the stone.

Full detail, photos and per-band economics in the Field Guide PDF · 2026-08-11.